



“ONDC has the ability to identify and resolve the challenges that come in the way of digitisation of small sellers and enables them to access a national customer base unlike before”

SANJEEV BARNWAL
FOUNDER AND CTO,
MEESHO



“In large cities, 85 per cent of consumers do their discovery phase online. If they believe that I can go to ONDC and check what’s available, ONDC would have done a great job”

KUMAR RAJAGOPALAN
CEO, RETAILERS
ASSOCIATION OF INDIA



“For ITC, which makes products for everyday consumption at all price points, a network that allows universal access for buyers to our products is a great opportunity”

B. SUMANT
EXECUTIVE
DIRECTOR, ITC



“Consumers need to know the ONDC value proposition—more choice, the ability to transact with nearby mom-and-pop stores, and single-point access to the seller universe across the country”

AMAR SHANKAR
PARTNER, GOVERNMENT
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CONSULTING, EY INDIA

erations and technical fronts. It is also working with the MSME ministry and various government agencies like SIDBI and NABARD to leverage their large base and machinery to on-board different sections of merchants. ONDC has also launched UP One District One Product (UP-ODOP) on the platform. It is providing incentives to sellers to persuade their physical world customers to order online. Kumar Rajagopalan, CEO of Retailers Association of India, says ONDC will make e-commerce truly omni-channel for sellers and customers. “The success of ONDC lies in inclusivity. The consumer will make or break it. Today, at least in large cities, 85 per cent of consumers do their discovery phase online. If 85 per cent believe that I can go to ONDC and check what’s available, I think they would have done a great job,” he says.

ONDC understands a lot more work needs to be done on the seller side. Version 1 was about building the protocol and proving that it is possible to interconnect these various elements to achieve an unbundled and interoperable transaction. Now the focus shifts to establishing standard operational behaviours among sellers and helping streamline implementation challenges including inventory management, cataloguing and packaging.

The good part is that, despite low volumes, there is a definite pick-up in transactions. “Earlier, it used to take time [for merchants] to accept an order. Now I have sellers accepting and getting it packed in a matter of minutes,”

says SellerApp’s Vamanan. “We know that it takes some time for this behavioural change to happen, but it is happening for a good percentage of sellers, much faster.”

ONDC feels the tipping point will arrive when no participant will need the network’s assistance in manoeuvring digital commerce. “They will be doing it all by themselves. A farmer will get another farmer, a weaver will get another weaver, and a home cook will get another home cook. They will tell each other. That is when it will take off. That’s the tipping point,” says Joshi. Koshy adds that ONDC’s role is to help this new system jump start, and then it will feed on its own. “Look at any large public good project. It takes time for social transformation to happen—we are talking about three to five years. What we are doing is priming of the pump; it will grow from there naturally. That’s the beauty of an open network,” he says.

By laying the foundation for an open platform that prioritises small merchants and streamlines the digital commerce experience, ONDC is creating the engine to drive e-commerce in India towards a more equitable, fair-competition era. If it succeeds, it will give the likes of Kudumbashree and the neighbourhood *kirana* store a true level-playing field against the giants of modern retail and the digital marketplaces. **BT**

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